that develop between parents and offspring and monogamous mates in mammals. "The feelings that infants or adults feel when being nurtured—warmth, calmness and peacefulness—come from a combination of opioids and oxytocin. These are the same feelings that people who take opioids report: a feeling of warmth and being nurtured or loved" (ibid.). Of course, peer pressure (in which individuals feel compelled to do what it takes to "fit in") is merely a variation of this theme. As one analyst concludes, "if we want to have less opioid use, we may have to figure out how to have more love" (ibid.).

Most importantly, the metatheoretical framework we use in this book enables us not only to delineate the different dimensions of a complex social issue, such as the opioid epidemic, but to see the interpenetration between them. Consider, for instance, a concrete example of opioid use discussed by sociologist Matthew Desmond in his award-winning book *Evicted* (2016). Desmond tells the story of a nurse named Scott who became addicted to opiates after a doctor prescribed him Percocet for back pain. The doctor's decision (individual/rational realm) to prescribe Scott Percocet was undoubtedly based on the parameters of his practice set by his training and the medical establishment in conjunction with insurance and pharmaceutical companies (collective/rational realm). Scott found that opioids gave him tremendous relief from not only physical but also emotional pain (individual/rational and individual/nonrational realms)—for in addition to his back problem, Scott had recently suffered the deaths of two friends from AIDS. That Scott's addiction occurred in the midst of the AIDS crisis, mired as it was in homophobia and a political-economic situation in which AIDS was not deemed a critical societal issue (but a "gay" one), reflects the collective/nonrational and collective/rational realms. Sadly, the feeling of relief Scott got from Percocet led him to try fentanyl, which he described as "the best feeling of pleasure and contentment I have ever felt" (Desmond 2016:83). Scott's life spun out of control. He eventually would lose his job and his home.

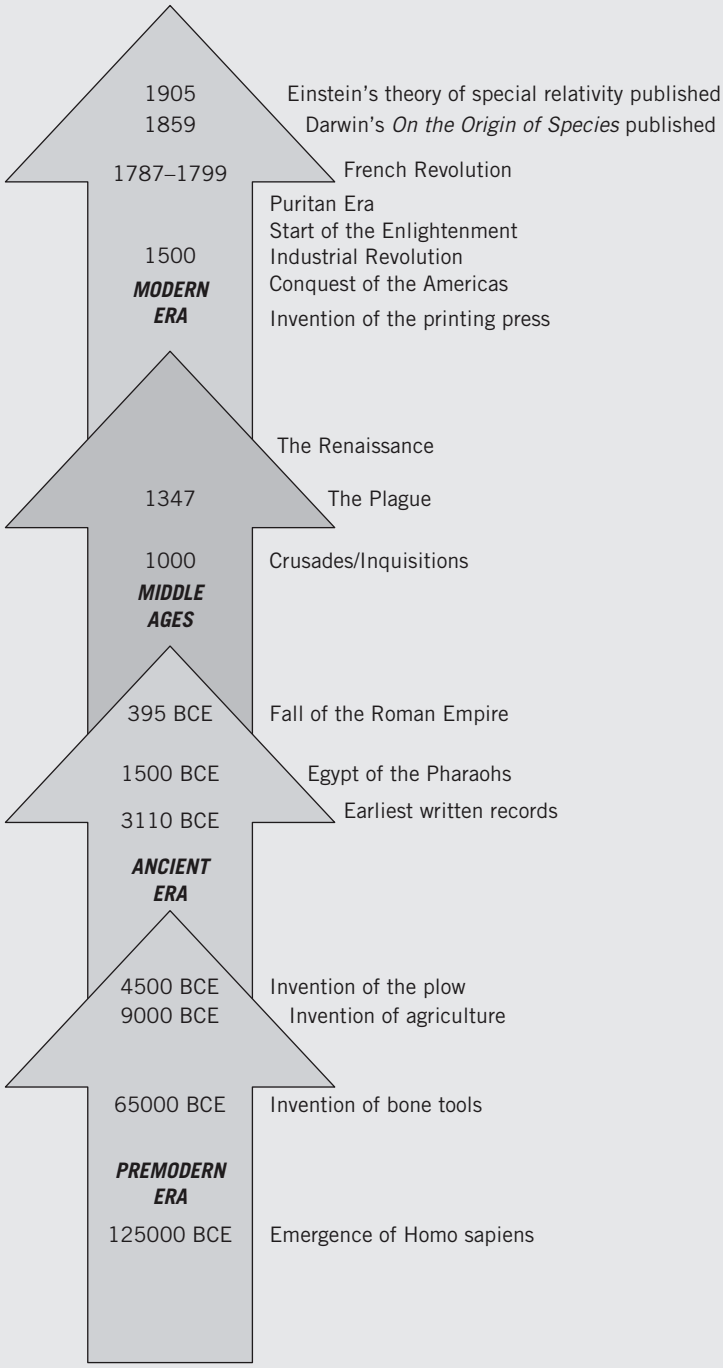
In sum, in the same way that we used the action/order theoretical framework to help us navigate the complex issue of the opioid epidemic, we use this theoretical framework throughout this book to help students navigate, and compare and contrast, the original works and central ideas of sociology's founding figures. But this raises an important question: Why are these the core theorists? After all, the discipline of sociology has been influenced by dozens of philosophers and social thinkers. Given this fact, is it right to hold up a handful of scholars as *the* core theorists of sociology, especially if doing so leads to the canonization of a few "dead, white, European men"?

In our view, the answer is yes, it is right (or at least not wrong) to cast a select group of intellectuals as the core writers in the discipline, and yes, this leads, to an extent, to the canonization of a few dead, white, European men. On the other hand, it is these thinkers from whom later social theorists (who are not all dead, white, European, or male) primarily have drawn for inspiration and insight. To better understand our rationale for including some theorists while excluding others, it is important first to briefly consider the historical context that set the stage for the development of sociology as a discipline.

The European Enlightenment

Many of the seeds for what would become sociology were first planted during the **Enlightenment**, a period of remarkable intellectual development that originated in

Figure 1.5 Historical Eras: A Partial Timeline



Europe during the late seventeenth and early eighteenth centuries (see Figure 1.5). The development of **civil society** (open spaces of debate relatively free from government control) and the quickening pace of the modern world enabled a newly emerging mass of literate citizens to think about the economic, political, and cultural conditions that shaped society. As a result, a number of long-standing ideas and beliefs about social life were turned upside down. The Enlightenment, however, was not so much a fixed set of ideas as it was a new attitude, a new method of thought. One of the most important aspects of this new attitude was an emphasis on *reason*, which demanded the questioning and reexamination of received ideas and values regarding the physical world, human nature, and their relationship to God.

Before the Enlightenment period, there were no institutionalized academic disciplines seeking to explain the workings of the natural and social worlds. Aside from folklore, there were only the interpretations of nature and humanity sanctioned by the Catholic Church. Based on myth and faith, such explanations of the conditions of existence took on a taken-for-granted quality that largely isolated them from criticism (Lemert 1993; Seidman 1994). Enlightenment intellectuals challenged myth- and faith-based truths by subjecting them to the dictates of reason and its close cousin, science. Scientific thought had itself only begun to emerge in the fifteenth century through the efforts of astronomers and scientists such as Copernicus, Galileo, and Bacon (see Figure 1.5). Copernicus's discovery in the early sixteenth century that the Earth orbited the Sun directly contradicted the literal understanding of the Bible, which placed the Earth at the center of the universe. With his inventive improvement to the telescope, Galileo confirmed Copernicus's heliocentric view the following century. Galileo's contemporary, Sir Francis Bacon, developed an experimental, inductive approach to analyzing the natural world for which he has come to be known as the "father of the scientific method." In advocating the triumph of reasoned investigation over faith, these early scientists and the Enlightenment intellectuals who followed in their footsteps rebuked existing knowledge as fraught with prejudice and mindless tradition (Seidman 1994:20–21). Not surprisingly, such views were dangerous because they challenged the authority of religious beliefs and those charged with advancing them. Indeed, Galileo was convicted of heresy by the Catholic Church, had his work banned, and spent the last 10 years of his life under house arrest for advocating a heliocentric view of the universe.

It is important to bear in mind, however, that Enlightenment thinkers did not set out to disprove the existence of God; with few exceptions, there were no admitted atheists during this period of European history. But though they did not deny that the universe was divinely created, they did deny that God and his work were inscrutable. Instead, they viewed the universe as a mechanical system composed of matter in motion that obeyed natural laws that could be uncovered by means of methodical observation and empirical research. Thus, when Newton developed his theory of gravity, a giant leap forward in the development of mathematics and physics, he was offering proof of God's existence. For Newton, only the intelligence of a divine power could have ordered the universe so perfectly around the sun as to prevent the planets from colliding under forces of gravity (Armstrong 1994:303). Similarly, René Descartes was convinced that reason and mathematics could provide certainty of God, whose existence could be demonstrated rationally, much like a geometric proof. Faith and reason for these individuals were not irreconcilable. The heresy committed by the Enlightenment thinkers was their attempt to solve the mystery of God's design of the

natural world through the methodical, empirical discovery of eternal laws. Miracles were for the ignorant and superstitious.

Later Enlightenment thinkers, inspired by growing sophistication within the fields of physics and mathematics, would begin to advance a view of science that sought to uncover not God's imprint in the universe but, rather, the natural laws of matter that ordered the universe independent of the will of a divine Creator. Scientific inquiry was no longer tied to proving God's existence. Belief in the existence of God was becoming more a private matter of conviction and conscience that could not be subjected to rational proof but rested instead on faith. Some of the most renowned physicists, mathematicians, and philosophers of modern Western societies, from Pascal and Spinoza to Kant, Diderot, and Hume, would come to see God as a comforting idea that could offer certainty and meaning in the world or as a way to represent the summation of the causal laws and principles that ordered the universe. God, however, was not understood as a transcendent, omniscient Being who was responsible for the design of the universe and all that happens in it. And if the existence of God could not be logically or scientifically proven, then faith in his existence mattered little in explanations of reality (Armstrong 1994:311–15, 341–43). There was no longer any room left in reason and science for God.

The rise of science and empiricism ushered in by the Enlightenment would give birth to sociology in the mid-nineteenth century. The central idea behind the emerging discipline was that society could be the subject of scientific examination in the same manner as biological organisms or the physical properties of material objects. Indeed, the French intellectual **Auguste Comte** (1798–1857; see the Significant Others box below), who coined the term "sociology" in 1839, also used the term "social physics" to refer to this new discipline, which reflects his view that sociologists should scientifically uncover the laws of the social world.[3] Specifically, for Comte, the new science of society—sociology—involved (1) the analysis of the central elements and functions of social systems, using (2) concrete historical and comparative methods in order to (3) establish testable generalizations about them (Fletcher 1966:14).[4]

Thus far, we have offered a brief overview of the new scientific approach to the world characteristic of the Enlightenment. However, both the Enlightenment in general and the later emergence of sociology as a discipline were also the cause and the effect of a host of social, economic, and political transformations that had been unfolding in Western Europe since the sixteenth century. It is to a review of some of these changes that we now turn.

The Industrial Revolution

One of the most important of these transformations was the **Industrial Revolution**, a period of enormous economic change that began in England in the eighteenth century. The term "Industrial Revolution" refers to the application

[3]Physics is often considered the most scientific and rational of all the natural sciences because it focuses on the basic elements of matter and energy and their interactions.

[4]Of course, the scientists of the Enlightenment were not uninfluenced by subjectivity or morality. Rather, as Seidman (1994:30–31) points out, paradoxically, the Enlighteners sacralized science, progress, and reason. They deified the creators of science such as Galileo and Newton and fervently believed that "science" could resolve all social problems and restore social order, which is itself a type of "faith."

Significant Others

Auguste Comte (1798–1857): The Father of "Social Physics"

Born in southern France during a most turbulent period in French history, Auguste Comte was himself a turbulent figure. Though he excelled as a student, he had little patience for authority. Indeed, his obstinate temperament prevented him from completing his studies at the newly established École Polytechnique, Paris's elite university. Nevertheless, Comte was able to make a name for himself in the intellectual circles of Paris. In 1817, he began working as a secretary and collaborator to Henri Saint-Simon. Their productive though fractious relationship came to an end seven years later in a dispute over assigning authorship to one of Comte's essays. Comte next set about developing his system of positivist philosophy while working in minor academic positions for meager wages. Beginning in 1826, Comte offered a series of private lectures in an effort to disseminate his views. Though these were attended by eminent thinkers, the grandiosity of his theoretical system led some to dismiss his ideas. Nevertheless, Comte continued undeterred: from 1830 to 1842, he worked single-mindedly on his magnum opus, the six-volume *The Positive Philosophy* (1830–1842/1974). In the series, Comte not only outlines his "Law of Three Stages" (which posits that science develops through three mentally conceived stages: [1] the theological stage, [2] the metaphysical stage, and [3] the positive stage) but also delineates the proper methods for his new science of "social physics" as well as its fundamental task—the study of social statics (order) and dynamics (progress). The work was well received in some scientific quarters, and Comte seemed poised to establish himself as a first-rate scholar. Unfortunately, his temperament again proved to be a hindrance to his success, both personal and professional. His troubled marriage ended soon after *The Positive Philosophy* was completed, and his petulance further alienated him from friends and colleagues while costing him a position at the École Polytechnique. Comte's life took a turn for the better, however, when in 1844 he met and fell in love with Clotilde de Vaux. Their affair did not last long; Clotilde developed tuberculosis and died within a year of their first meeting. Comte dedicated the rest of his life to "his angel." In her memory, he founded the Religion of Humanity, for which he proclaimed himself the high priest. The new church was founded on the principle of universal love as Comte abandoned his earlier commitment to science and positivism. Until his death in 1857, Comte sought not supporters for his system of science but converts to his Positive Church.

Source: This account of Comte's biography is based largely on Lewis Coser's (1977) discussion in *Masters of Sociological Thought*.

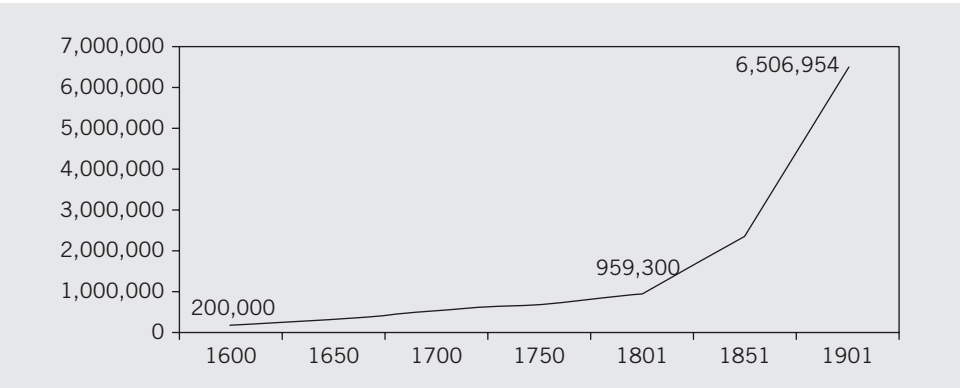
of power-driven machinery to agriculture, transportation, and manufacturing. Although industrialization began in remote times and continues today, this process completely transformed Europe in the eighteenth century. It turned Europe from a predominantly agricultural to a predominantly industrial society. It not only radically altered how goods were produced and distributed but galvanized the system of capitalism as well.

Before the advance of modern industrialization, social life in Europe revolved around the family and kinship networks defined by blood and marriage relations. The family served as the fundamental unit for socializing individuals into the moral codes that reinforced expected patterns of behavior. In addition to its educational role, the family was also the center of production and thus responsible for the material well-being of its members. Family members grew their own food, managed their own livestock, built their own shelters, welled their own water, and made their own clothes.

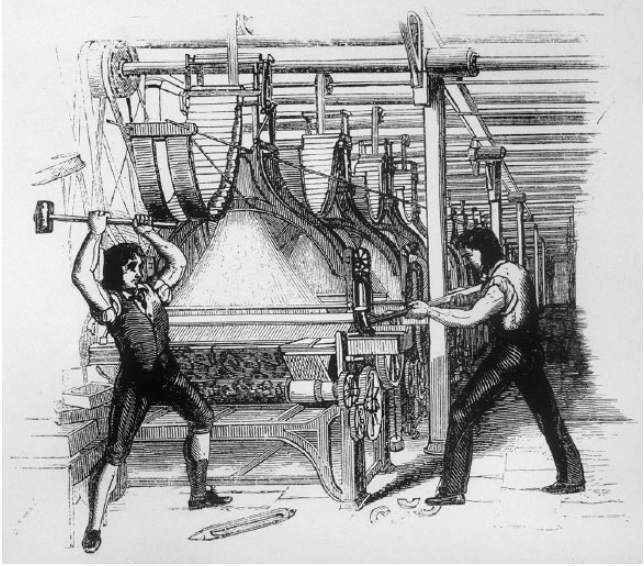
In short, the family depended on the skills and ingenuity of its members, and those in the broader kinship network of which it was a part, for its survival. The family as a separate private sphere, distinct from and dependent on external economic and political institutions, did not yet exist. Likewise, the idea that one may embark on a "career" or envision alternative futures, such that "anything is possible," was inconceivable (Brown 1987:48).

The rise of industrialization, however, dramatically reshaped the organization of society. Most of the world's population was rural before the Industrial Revolution, but by the mid-nineteenth century, half of the population of England lived in cities. As shown in Figure 1.6, the population of London grew from less than a million in 1800 to more than six and a half million in 1901. So too throughout Europe, the population was becoming increasingly urban. By the end of the nineteenth century, half of the population of Europe lived in cities. Moreover, while there were scarcely any cities in Europe with populations of 100,000 in 1800, there were more than 150 cities that size a century later. This massive internal migration resulted from large numbers of people leaving farms and agricultural work to become wage earners in factories in the rapidly growing cities. The shift to factory production and wage labor meant that families were no longer the center of economic activity. Instead of producing their own goods for their own needs, families depended for their survival on impersonal labor and commodity markets. At the same time, states were establishing public bureaucracies, staffed by trained "functionaries," to provide a standardized education for children and to adjudicate disputes, punish rule violators, and guarantee recently enshrined individual rights. As a result of these transformations, the family was becoming increasingly privatized, its range of influence confined more and more to its own closed doors. The receding sway of family and community morality was coupled with the decline of the Church and religious worldviews. In their place came markets and bureaucratic organizations speaking their language of competition, profit, individual success, and instrumental efficiency. With the reorganization of society around the twin pillars of mass production and commerce, the "seven deadly sins became lively capitalist virtues: avarice became acumen; sloth, leisure; and pride, ambition" (Brown 1987:57).

Figure 1.6 London Population, 1600–1901



The shift from agricultural to factory production had particularly profound effects on individuals. Technological changes brought ever-more-efficient machines and a growing routinization of tasks. For instance, with the introduction of the power loom in the textile industry, an unskilled worker could produce three and a half times as much as could the best handloom weaver. However, this rise in efficiency came at a tremendous human cost. Mechanized production reduced both the number of jobs available and the technical skills needed for work in the factory. Workers engaged in increasingly specialized and repetitive tasks that deprived them of meaningful connections with other workers, with the commodities they produced, and even with their own abilities. As the **division of labor**—the separation of a work process into a number of specialized tasks—increased and the work became more uniform, so did the workers themselves, who were as interchangeable as the mass-produced commodities they produced. A few profited enormously, but most worked long hours for low wages. Accidents were frequent and often quite serious. Workers were harshly punished and their wages were docked for the slightest mistakes. Women and children worked alongside men in noisy, unsafe conditions. Most factories were dirty, poorly ventilated and lit, and dangerous. From the 1760s onward, labor disputes began to result in sporadic outbreaks of violent resistance. Perhaps most famous were the episodes of machine-breaking that occurred in England in what has since become known as the Luddite disturbances. As you will read in the next chapter, it was precisely these dire circumstances that spawned Karl Marx's commitment to the revolutionary overthrow of capitalism.



© Mary Evans Picture Library/Alamy

Photo 1.1

This publicly distributed illustration shows frame-breakers, or Luddites, smashing a Jacquard loom in the nineteenth century. Machine-breaking was criminalized by Parliament as early as 1721, but Luddites met a heated response, and Parliament passed the Frame Breaking Act of 1812, which enabled the death penalty for machine-breakers.

Source: Binfield, Kevin, ed. 2004. *What the Luddites Really Wanted*. Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press.

Political and Religious Transformations

Part and parcel of the economic transformations taking place in Europe in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries were revolutionary political changes. The first English parliament was established in 1215 with the historic signing of the Magna Carta, but for the next 400 years, England (and the rest of Europe) was ruled by an absolute monarchy whose authority rested in the belief in the divine right of kings. Tumultuous clashes between the Parliament and the kings over the division of power led the king to dissolve the Parliament at times, and the struggles between loyalists to the monarchy and those who sought to secure and expand the powers of parliament culminated in the English Civil War (1642–1651). The Parliamentarians were victorious, which resulted in the execution of King Charles I in 1649 and, of more lasting consequence, the end of the monarchy's absolute rule. However, Charles II (the son and heir of the executed Charles I) cobbled together

an army of royalists and returned as king in 1660, ushering in a period known as the Restoration. The Restoration would collapse with the eruption of the Glorious Revolution of 1688 and the passage of the Bill of Rights in 1689, which codified the extent of the monarch's power while granting new, legally guaranteed powers to parliament.

Yet these partisan clashes were about not only politics but also religion. The British monarch, whose rule was based on "divine right," was considered the head of the Church of England (the Anglican Church), and by law, everyone in England was supposed to belong to the Church. But in the seventeenth century, independent churches began to form, which challenged the authority of both the monarchy and the Church. The first meeting of what would become the Baptist Church took place in 1612, and by the end of the century, sects of Puritans, Congregationalists, Independents, and Quakers had emerged, all of whom believed that congregations had the right to run their own affairs without interference. Supporters of the Church of England fought back with new laws, such as the Act of Uniformity of 1662, which mandated that all clergy must use the Book of Common Prayer, and the Conventicle Act of 1664, which forbade unauthorized religious meetings of more than five people (unless they were all of the same household). Defiant church leaders, such as the founder of the Quakers, George Fox (1624–1691), were persecuted and imprisoned, while other religious rebels, most famously the Puritans, fled to the New World.

The French Revolution

Europe was awash in political and religious clashes in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries. But undoubtedly one of the most significant of these events was the French Revolution (1787–1799). Inspired in large part by Rousseau's *The Social Contract* (1762; discussed later in the chapter), the basic principle of the French Revolution, as contained in its primary manifesto, "La Déclaration des Droits de l'Homme et du Citoyen" ("The Declaration of Rights of Man and of the Citizen"; National Assembly of France 1789), was that "all men are born and remain free and equal in rights." Spurred by the philosophies of the Enlightenment and counter-Enlightenment, revolutionaries toppled the *ancien régime*, or old rule, that for centuries had consolidated wealth, land, and power in the hands of the clergy and a nobility based on heredity. Government would no longer be justified on the basis of a sacred, inviolable relation between rulers and subjects. Reason would be substituted for tradition, and equal rights for privilege, and "liberty, fraternity, and equality" would prevail. Because the revolutionaries sought to build a constitutional government from the bottom up, the French Revolution stimulated profound political rethinking about the nature of government and its proper relation to its citizens and set the stage for democratic uprisings throughout Europe.

However, the French Revolution sparked a bloody aftermath, making it clear that even democratic revolutions involve tremendous social disruption and that heinous deeds can be done in the name of freedom. The public beheading of King Louis XVI in the *Place de la Révolution* ("Revolution Square") ushered in what would come to be called the "Reign of Terror." Led by Maximilien Robespierre, radical democrats rounded up and executed anyone—whether on the left or right of the political spectrum—suspected of being opposed to the revolution. In the months between September 1793 (when Robespierre took power) and July 1794

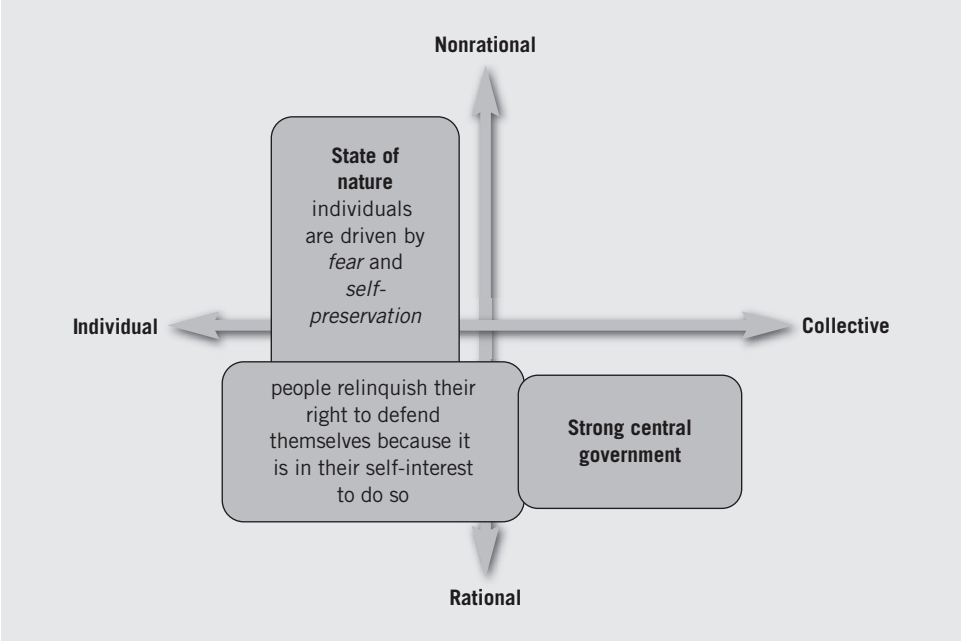
(when Robespierre was overthrown and executed), revolutionary zealots, under the auspices of the newly created "Committee of Public Safety," arrested about 300,000 people, executed some 17,000, and imprisoned thousands more. It was during this radical period of the Republic that the guillotine, adopted as an efficient and merciful method of execution, became the symbol of the Terror. While the years following the French Revolution by no means drew a straight line to creating a democratically elected government guaranteeing the rights and equality of all, its effects nevertheless reverberated across the continent. The legitimacy of monarchial rule and inherited privilege that had undergirded European societies for centuries was now challenged by a worldview that sought to place the direction of political and economic life into the hands of individuals armed with the capacity to reason.

In sum, it was against a backdrop of volatile political, economic, and religious change that Enlightenment thinkers developed their philosophies and, later, that sociology as a unique discipline would emerge. The steady erosion of monarchical and ecclesiastical authority, and the more general collapse of feudal society, compelled Enlightenment thinkers to come to grips with the question of *order*. Without the king or Church as the unequivocal foundation of society, how would social order be maintained? What would ensure that the social fabric would remain intact? Would the individual capacity for rational thought be enough to secure social stability? Or would the rationality and emerging autonomy of the individual result in prizing one's own interest over and against that of the broader society? Are the interests of the individual and those of the society in fundamental conflict? Could the rational interests of the individual and the broader society be in harmony? What mechanisms would enable the synthesis of individual and collective interests? These are the fundamental issues that the Enlightenment philosophers explored.

Enlightenment Thinkers and the Questions of Order and Action

One of the most important thinkers to emerge during the Enlightenment period was the English philosopher **Thomas Hobbes** (1588–1679). Oftentimes regarded as "the founder of modern social thought" (Kimmel and Stephen 1998:4), Hobbes was "the first thinker to see the necessity of explaining why human society is not a 'war of all against all'" (Wrong 1961:185). Hobbes subscribed to a then-radical view that championed the natural equality of all individuals. At the same time, however, Hobbes maintained that humans are naturally asocial, driven by selfishness, violence, and fear, and that in "a state of nature" it is legitimate for individuals to use whatever means are at their disposal to survive to ensure self-preservation. Given these alleged "natural" traits, Hobbes maintained that absolute authority is the only thing that can hold society together. Peace and prosperity can be maintained only if individuals agree to relinquish their freedoms to a central government—the Leviathan—that ruled through the consent of the people. Rational individuals agree to relinquish their "natural" right to defend themselves, thereby giving the central government the sole authority to protect citizens. Likewise, it is in the rational interest of individuals to permit the central government to restrain the strong from exploiting the weak (see Figure 1.7). This exchange of some individual liberty for some common security is the famous "social contract" for which Hobbes is well known. In his masterpiece of political philosophy, *Leviathan* (1651/1991),

Figure 1.7 Hobbes's Basic Theoretical Orientation



Hobbes maintains that without the controlling force of an absolute authority, our lives would be "nasty, brutish, and short." Men would be in a chronic state of fear, insecurity, and violence—a "war of all against all." As Hobbes (1651/1991) famously states:

> Whatsoever therefore is consequent to a time of Warre, where every man is Enemy to every man; the same is consequent to the time, wherein men live without other security, than what their own strength, and their own invention shall furnish them withall. In such condition, there is no place for Industry; because the fruit thereof is uncertain; and consequently no Culture of the Earth; no Navigation, nor use of the commodities that may be imported by Sea; no commodious Building; no Instruments of moving, and removing such things as require much force; no Knowledge of the face of the Earth; no account of Time; no Arts; no Letters; no Society; and which is worst of all, continuall feare, and danger of violent death; And the life of man, solitary, poore, nasty, brutish, and short. (89)

Hobbes's defense of the absolute right of kings—not because this right was endowed by God, but because it was rooted in a consensual social contract—infuriated both monarchists who believed in the divine right of kings, and parliamentarians, such as Locke and Rousseau (discussed shortly), who eschewed monarchism altogether.

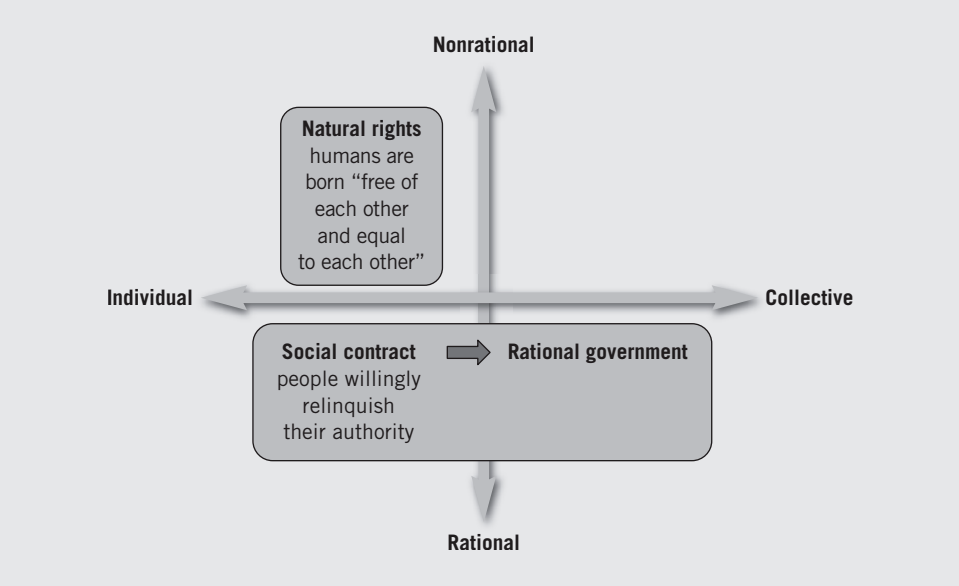
For his part, the so-called father of liberalism, **John Locke** (1632–1704), answered the question of order in a considerably different way than his compatriot Hobbes. Like Hobbes, Locke viewed individuals as innately "free of each other

and equal to each other" (Thomson 2010:18). But Locke rejected Hobbes's view of humans as governed by self-preservation. He disputed the false dichotomy that Hobbes posed between despotism and anarchy, and he rejected Hobbes's assessment of humans as so competitive and intent on maximizing their own gain that only absolute authority could hope to restrain them. Instead, Locke maintained that human beings were governed by "natural laws" derived from the Creator. These laws of nature included an individuals' right to their person as well as to their possessions. As Locke states, because all mankind is equal and independent, "no one ought to harm another in his Life, Health, Liberty or Possessions" (Locke 1689/1988, as cited by Thomson 2010:19). Locke viewed humans as capable of using reason and rationality to create governments whose authority would be based not on despotism and force but on consensually established impersonal laws, designed to protect free and equal citizens' "natural" rights to "life, liberty, and estate" (see Figure 1.8).

For Locke, the powers of the constitutional government must be contractually granted by the majority of free men. Because government is based on a social contract between free and equal parities advancing their mutual interest, its main function is to judge the disputes of citizens fairly and equally and to enforce the laws on everyone (Thomson 2010:20). This notion of popular sovereignty—the notion that no one was above the law—was the radical crux of Locke's writing: people have the right to choose their government and the right to rebel against a sovereign who has violated the social contract. Thus, in stark contrast to Hobbes (who, as we have seen, viewed absolute authority as essential to preventing social conflict), Locke advocated the overturning of arbitrary, despotic monarchies, by revolution if necessary.

Locke's views on human nature, reason, equality, and rule by popular consent would inspire many of the leading figures of the American Revolution. Indeed,

Figure 1.8 Locke's Basic Theoretical Orientation



historians commonly portray Locke as "the single most important influence that shaped the founding of the United States" (ushistory.org 2020).

In terms of our theoretical framework, in advocating the triumph of reasoned investigation over faith, Enlighteners such as Hobbes and Locke celebrated a rationalistic approach to action—the human ability to overcome nonrational sentiments or use them for the collective good (see Figure 1.7 and Figure 1.8). Although they viewed the essence of human nature differently—with Hobbes emphasizing the innate drives of (nonrational) fear and (rational) self-interest, and Locke emphasizing the (nonrational) natural rights endowed by the Creator—Hobbes and Locke concurred as to the (individual/rational) motivation behind relinquishing authority to a strong central government to ensure social order (collective/rational realm).

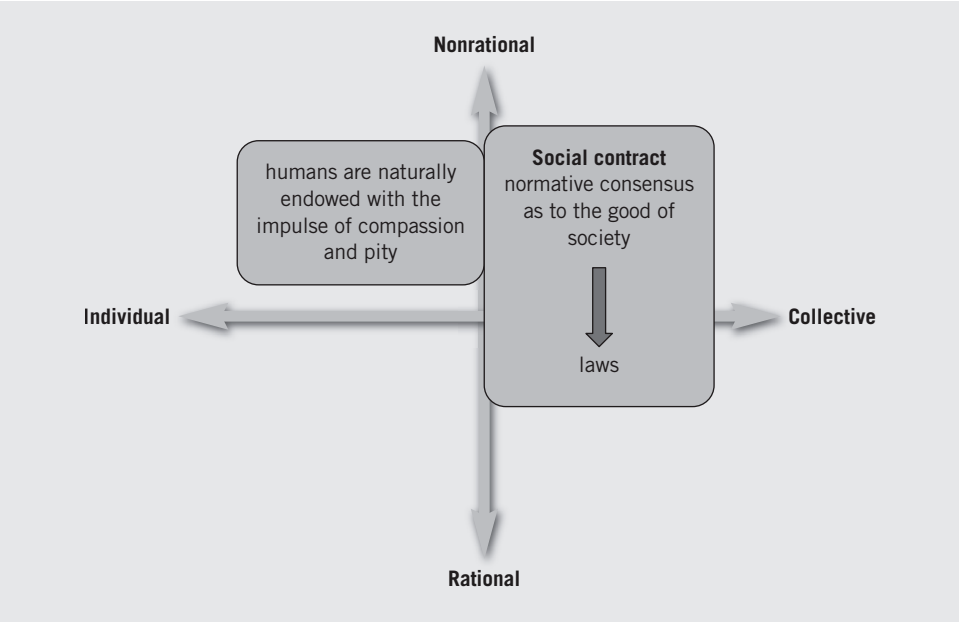
It was precisely this unabashed embrace of rationality that was behind a romantic reaction to the Enlightenment, called the **counter-Enlightenment**, that began to take root in the eighteenth century. Concerned about the disorganizing effects brought about by the dizzying pace of industrialization and urbanization, counter-Enlighteners such as **Jean-Jacques Rousseau** (1712–1778) highlighted the importance of nonrational factors, such as tradition, emotions, ritual, and ceremony, to the stability of society. Like Hobbes, Rousseau asserted that humans in their natural state were guided by the principle of self-preservation. Unlike Hobbes, however, Rousseau viewed humans as naturally endowed with the impulse of compassion and pity and argued that solitary humans in a state of nature would express the virtues of simplicity and essential goodness, having "not the slightest notion of mine and thine" (Thomson 2010:39). Writing on the corrupting influence of possessions and self-interest, Rousseau remarked:

> The first man who, having enclosed a piece of ground, to whom it occurred to say *this is mine*, and found people sufficiently simple to believe him was the true founder of civil society. How many crimes, wars, murders, how many miseries and horrors Mankind would have been spared by him who, pulling up the stakes or filling in the ditch, had cried out to his kind: Beware of listening to this impostor; You are lost if you forget that the fruits are everyone's and the Earth no one's. (Rousseau, *Foundations of Inequality*, p. 60, as cited in Thomson 2010:40)

Indeed, in his first published work, *Discourse on the Arts and Sciences* (1749; see Gay 1987), Rousseau controversially argued that it was human institutions that contributed to the corruption of morals. In a scathing attack on scientific progress and civilization, Rousseau contended that the human species is better, wiser, and happier in its primitive state and evil to the extent that it moves away from this natural condition. He saw nature, including human nature, as essentially good—and the supreme good as freedom. The more natural and "uncivilized" the human group, the less corrupt they are, while the allegedly superior rational faculties leave us lifeless and cold, uncertain and unsure.

Akin to Locke, Rousseau tied social order to a "social contract," yet in contrast to Locke (and Hobbes), who rooted order in a (rational) contract between the people and a ruler, Rousseau grounded the social contract in a (nonrational) normative consensus or the "will of the people" (Wrong 1994:9; see Figure 1.9). Rousseau believed that social order is best maintained not by the coercive power of a central authority but by people willingly obeying the laws because they helped make them. In order to have a free and equal society, everyone must participate in creating laws for the good of

Figure 1.9 Rousseau's Basic Theoretical Orientation

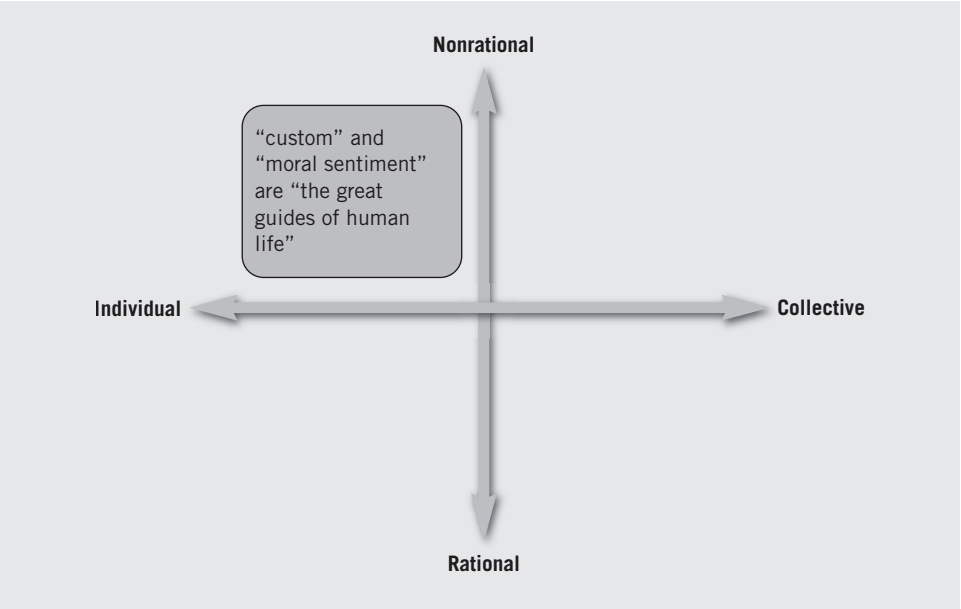


society (the social contract), which, as shown in Figure 1.9, situates social order in the collective/nonrational realm. In short, while Hobbes and Locke celebrated the (social) *contract*, Rousseau celebrated the *social* (contract), that is, the collective good.

Yet Rousseau doubted that a genuinely democratic government was possible. His depiction of a society based on a contract between free and equal people expressing their general will was hypothetical, and he used this hypothetical society to criticize the oppressive and restrictive government of his day. Indeed, a social contract that legitimates the use of force to compel an individual to obey the general will may result in the majority oppressing a minority, which contradicts the "natural order" in which individuals are "free of each other and equal to each other." In other words, if the individual has natural liberty, his interests may conflict with the common interest of the society as a whole. As Rousseau (1792, as cited in Thomson 2010) states, "man was born free, and everywhere he is chains" (38).

David Hume (1711–1776) was another Enlightenment philosopher who sought to uncover the foundations of society in the wake of the demise of ecclesiastical and monarchical authority. Like Locke and Hobbes, Hume embraced the notion that individuals possess the capacity for reason. Yet, perhaps because he was writing during a period of relative peace, Hume maintained that societal stability rested on individuals becoming "accustomed to obedience" to the law so that justice is administered and peace and safety are ensured (Hume 1777/2006:314, 315). Social order was thus attributed to the weight of habit and custom, that is, the nonrational realm (see Figure 1.10). According to Hume, it is habit and custom that restrain our passions and motivate us to hold up our social obligations, rather than rational cost/benefit calculations aimed at furthering our self-interests. Our daily conduct—and social order more generally—is shaped by recurring experiences that lead to the repetitive or "customary" association between concepts (e.g., knowing to stand in

Figure 1.10 Hume's Basic Theoretical Orientation



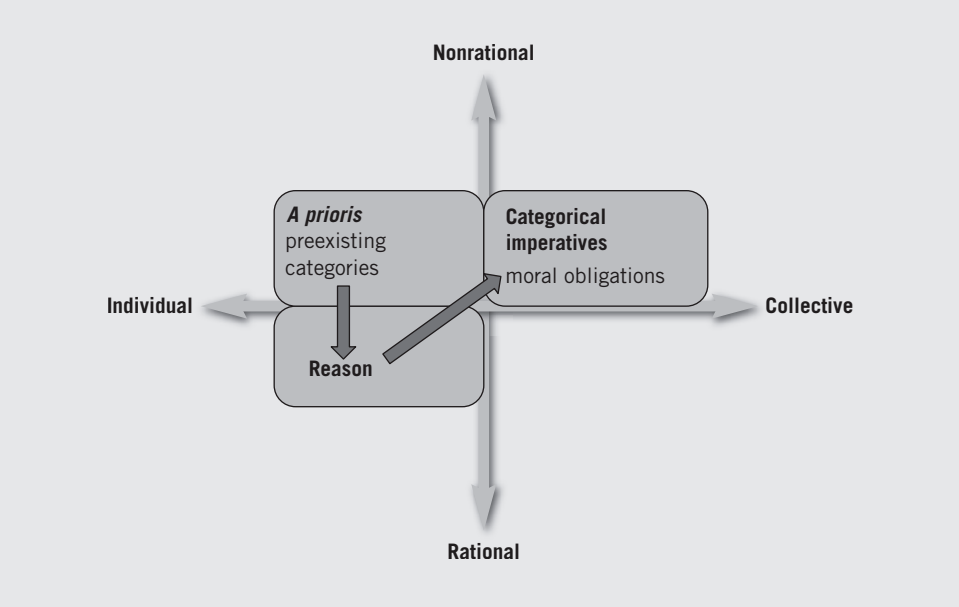
line while waiting). In this way, our actions are guided less by any sort of conscious, deliberative weighing of cause and effect. As Hume (1748/2007) states:

> Custom . . . is the great guide of human life. It is that principle alone which renders our experience useful to us, and makes us expect, for the future, a similar train of events with those which have appeared in the past. Without the influence of custom, we should be entirely ignorant of every matter of fact beyond what is immediately present to the memory and senses. We should never know how to adjust means to ends, or to employ our natural powers in the production of any effect. (31)

Relatedly, Hume contended that while the utility of particular means for achieving our ends can be subjected to a rational calculation, the "ultimate" ends of our actions are not evaluated relative to whether or not they serve our self-interest but are judged according to the "sentiments and affections of mankind, without any dependence on the intellectual faculties" (Hume 1751/2006:273). It is not reason but, rather, "moral sentiment"—"a feeling for the happiness of mankind, and a resentment of their misery"—that allows us to distinguish between virtue and vice (ibid.:269).

Like Rousseau and Hume, the Prussian philosopher **Immanuel Kant** (1724–1804) was also wary of the increasingly rationalistic nature of modern society. Though he considered *secularization* (the declining significance of religion) the defining characteristic of his era, he understood the need to preserve the moral compass provided by religion. In an extraordinary blend of nonrational and rational motivation, Kant recast the essential religious maxims into secular terms, which he called "categorical imperatives" (see Figure 1.11). Categorical imperatives are moral obligations derived from *reason* rather than religion. For Kant, the highest form of reason is when individuals raise themselves

Figure 1.11 Kant's Basic Theoretical Orientation



above their own particular point of view in order to see and understand universal truths. Acting morally means making your actions conform to those universally valid rules and maxims that impersonal reasoning can deduce. Thus, moral behavior should be a function of our *intellect* rather than our emotions or irrational beliefs (such as the fear of God or a preoccupation with salvation). Consider, for instance, Kant's recasting of the "Golden Rule" (do unto others as you would have them do unto you) as this: *act according to only that maxim by which you can at the same time will that it shall become a universal law*. Kant's point is that rather than obey the Golden Rule because it is "God-given," we can have the same result by imagining the consequences of our actions if everyone were to act the same way. This enables us to act according to what is "categorically" best for everyone in all cases, rather than simply our own self-interest. According to Kant, freedom comes not from doing whatever we want (as libertarians would have it) but from the ability to use our minds; those who act according to their own passions or self-interests or those of others are "slaves."

In his 800-page opus, *Critique of Pure Reason* (1781/1987), Kant argued that rather than being a blank slate, the human mind contains structures that organize our perceptions. Kant used the term *a prioris* to refer to these universal elements in all knowledge that inhere in the mind from birth. *A prioris*, which include concepts such as time, space, and cause and effect, are subjective "'intuitions' that exist *prior to* experience and are necessary to make sense of it" (Thomson 2010:65, emphasis added). For Kant, the never-ending streams of sensory impressions that confront the individual would have no unity or pattern without this *a priori* (preexisting) framework to give them form and meaning (see Figure 1.11). Kant's focus on meaning, and the question of how meaning is created, has been particularly influential in the development of sociology. As you will see in the following chapters, core classical theorists such as Durkheim, Weber, Simmel, and Mead all devised their theories of meaning by explicitly drawing on Kant.

The Limits of Enlightenment

Thus far, we have seen that Enlightenment thinking paved the way for both modern liberalism and the development of the discipline of sociology. However, it is imperative to note that "race" as we understand it—a biological taxonomy that turns physical difference into relations of domination—and racism are products of the Enlightenment as well. Scientific theories of race, that is, "scientific" classifications of humanity into racial hierarchies in which those at the bottom were deemed inferior and unable to assimilate to the culture of superior races, emerged right alongside the notion of the "natural equality of all individuals" during the Enlightenment. This is not coincidental. Scientific racism and white supremacy adroitly resolved "the fundamental contradiction between professing liberty and upholding slavery" (Bouie 2018). And the very term "Enlightenment" gave legitimacy to the long-held racist "connection between lightness and Whiteness and reason, on the one hand, and darkness and Blackness and ignorance on the other" (Kendi 2016:80–81).

Indeed, Kant was among the first to explicitly articulate a theory of scientific racism that continues to haunt modern society to this day. In addition to his dense philosophical works, Kant wrote essays on a variety of topics, including politics, law, aesthetics, astronomy, geography, and history. In his anthropological writings, Kant equated race with reason, stating that "humanity is at its greatest perfection in the race of the whites" (Sica 2004:59). Kant asserted the moral as well as intellectual superiority of (white) Northern Europeans over the "unreason" and savagery of the rest of the world (Eze 1997:5). In a similar vein, although Locke championed the idea that each of us, by virtue of being human, has inalienable rights that no organized entity can strip away, he also had a financial stake in a slave trading company, and he helped draft documents that explicitly granted citizens the right to own "negro slaves" as well (Kimmel and Stephen 1998:vii). When Locke insisted that people were equal, he really meant white, propertied males. Yet, most significantly, it was not only Kant and Locke but the vast majority of Enlightenment thinkers who subscribed to a virulent white supremacy. Enlighteners were divided not between those who were white supremacists and those who were not but between those who used Enlightenment race "science" to argue that the Negro "species" had serious anatomical and cognitive deficiencies that "destined them for slavery" and more "liberal" thinkers who advocated for an "enlightened form of slavery" that encouraged slave owners to treat their slaves kindly (Curran 2019:367).[5]

To be sure, Enlightenment intellectuals' presumption of the inherent rationality and equality of human beings did not extend to women, either. **Mary Wollstonecraft** (1759–1797), often deemed "the first feminist," was among the first to apply the idea of natural rights to women. Wollstonecraft suffered a tumultuous childhood in London, as her father squandered the family's money and flew into drunken rages. In 1778, Wollstonecraft decided to strike out on her own, but she was frustrated by the lack of career options for educated but poor women (eloquently described in a chapter aptly titled "Unfortunate Situation of Females, Fashionably Educated, and Left Without a Fortune" in her book Thoughts on the Education of Daughters, 1787).

[5]Louis de Jaucourt (1704–1779) and Denis Diderot (1713–1784) are two important exceptions here. According to Curran (2019:168; 365–66), de Jaucourt unambiguously proclaimed that slavery "violates religion, morality, natural law, and all the rights of human nature" and argued that Africans who had been taken as slaves had the right to declare themselves free, while Diderot rejected the era's illegitimate race science and forcefully attacked what he believed to be his era's most glaring evil: the business of African chattel slavery.

In 1786, Wollstonecraft made the radical decision to try to earn her living as an author—a path that few women pursued in her day. She dedicated herself to learning French and German and translating texts (most notably *Of the Importance of Religious Opinions* by Jacques Necker and *Elements of Morality, for the Use of Children* by Christian Gotthilf Salzmann) and writing both fiction and nonfiction. Wollstonecraft was among the first writers to critique the conservative Edmund Burke's denunciation of the French Revolution. First published anonymously, *A Vindication of the Rights of Men* (1790) was an overnight success, and the second edition came out in December of that year with Wollstonecraft's authorship revealed. Wollstonecraft was compared favorably with such luminary Enlightenment thinkers as Thomas Paine, whose *Rights of Man* (1791; see ushistory.org n.d.) similarly condemned Burke's support of the monarchy. Wollstonecraft followed *A Vindication of the Rights of Men* (1790) with *A Vindication of the Rights of Women* (1792), which would prove to be Wollstonecraft's most famous and influential work. Here, she eloquently argued that women were human beings deserving of the same rights as men, not ornaments to society or property to be traded in marriage.

In *A Vindication of the Rights of Women (1792)*, Wollstonecraft argued against the tyranny of kingship, the Church, and the patriarchal family. Her central focus, however, was equality in education and the opening up of professions to women. Wollstonecraft shocked readers by maintaining that boys and girls should be educated together and that men should value women as rational beings and not mere objects of pleasure. She lamented the social construction of women as sentimental creatures, and she maintained that women colluded in their own oppression by accepting their political powerlessness and using their sexual power to seduce men (Kimmel and Stephen 1998:84). As Wollstonecraft (*A Vindication of the Rights of Women*, as cited in Kimmel and Stephen 1998) states:

> I wish to persuade women to endeavor to acquire strength, both of mind and body, and to convince them that the soft phrases, susceptibility of heart, delicacy of sentiment, and refinement of taste, are synonymous with epithets of weakness, and that those beings who are only the objects of pity and that kind of love, which has been termed its sister, will soon become objects of contempt . . . the first object of laudable ambition is to obtain a character as a human being, regardless of the distinction of sex. (91)

The Ins and Outs of the Sociological Theory "Canon"

Thus far, we have argued that the central figures at the heart of classical sociological theory all sought to explain the extraordinary economic, political, and social transformations taking place in Europe in the late nineteenth century. Yet concerns about the nature of social bonds and how these bonds can be maintained in the face of extant social change existed long before the eighteenth century and in many places, not only in Western Europe. Indeed, in the late fourteenth century, Abdel Rahman Ibn-Khaldun (1332–1406), born in Tunis, North Africa, wrote extensively on subjects that have much in common with contemporary sociology (Martindale 1981:134–36; Ritzer and Goodman 2004:5). And long before the fourteenth century, Plato (ca. 428–ca. 347 BCE), Aristotle (384–322 BCE), and Thucydides (ca. 460–ca. 400 BCE) wrote about the